Hump Day

By Lynda van Devanter

INTRODUCTION

Lynda van Devanter was an army nurse who served in Vietnam in 1969 and '70 at the 71st evacuation hospital in Pleiku. She began and led the Vietnam Veterans of America's Women's Writing Project and counseled many other veterans. She died on November 15th, 2002 from a cancer as a result of exposure to Agent Orange. Her story lives on. "Hump Day" by Lynda van Devanter

LYNDA: The largest number of people I grew up with grew up with a sense that we had a mission. We had a purpose to our lives, and that we had a responsibility to give something back to this world, and I was part of a generation of Americans who were chosen to change the world. We were sure of that. It was only a matter of waiting until we all grew up. We were the kid next door, both men and women. What I saw in Vietnam was not men. What I saw in Viet Nam was boys. They were kids. They were

4NG Fanatics

generally 17, 18, and 19 years old. And for those of us who were women in Viet Nam, we were barely out of nursing school. We were basically these naïve, idealistic kids of the 50's and 60's who thought of Kennedy in the same breath with, "Ask not what your country can do for you, ask what you can do for your country." We thought of Kennedy in the same breath with, "This generation will pay any price, bear any burden, to save this world for democracy." I was a citizen of the greatest country in the world, and I was about to give part of my self to keep America great. We were carried along by the noble sentiments of John Fitzgerald Kennedy, and honest to God, I mean, it beat in my heart. It beat in all of our hearts. It really did. And so, nursing was the way that I was going to make my contribution to society. As we began our odyssey into Viet Nam, as we began our odyssey into the new people that we were eventually to become, it was a process that I

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think we had hoped we would be able to ease our way into, and it didn't quite turn out that way. The day that I arrived in Viet Nam, I arrived in --- --- at the 90th replacement battalion, I learned that 2nd lieutenant Sharon Lane, who was a nurse on a ward at the 312th evacuation hospital at Cu Chi, had been killed that morning when a rocket had landed on her ward. I suddenly became very aware that women could in fact be in danger, and that this was no game anymore. Although the instructors back in basic had warned us what to expect, no amount of warning could ever have prepared me for the sheer numbers of mutilated young bodies that the helicopter kept bringing to the 71st. Dead bodies in glad bags were still being lined up outside the ER door, to be moved to the morgue as there was time. The moans and screams of so many wounded were mixed up with the shouted orders of doctors and nurses. So much for easing my way in.

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What I came to realize was we developed a living, breathing relationship with Death as a human entity. Death became somebody who we had a relationship with, and Death became somebody to fight sometimes and welcome sometimes. And when we fought with Death, we fought tooth and nail. And we used every tool at hand, and a lot of times the only tool we had was cursing it out because we were so enraged at it. As each day passed, I found myself growing a harder and harder shell to protect my emotions. I started listening to the local discontents, who railed against Nixon, Congress, the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and the whole U.S. government. Every time another person died on my table, I came one step closer to agreeing with them. As each day passed, I found myself growing a harder and harder shell to protect my emotions. I started listening to the local discontents, who railed against Nixon, Congress, the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and the whole U.S. government. Every

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time another person died on my table, I came one step closer to agreeing with them. And one day I saw some dead American soldiers lying outside the morgue. They had been ambushed by an NVA unit. The butchers had cut off our soldiers penises and stuffed them into the GI's mouths. I was outraged by the scene, but not as outraged as I became when I later saw a similar scene, only this time with dead Viet Cong.

During those months, I lost my direction and found myself becoming a person I would never have been before Viet Nam. Maybe, you would have said I was merely getting tough. Like thousands of Americans, I began calling the Vietnamese, both friendly and enemy, gooks. I would have thought I was above that sort of racism. After all, hadn't I marched in the United States for civil rights like a good Catholic girl who believed all oppression was wrong? For each one of us, there was someone

4NG Fanatics

who seemed to personify what the war was, its futility, its desperation, and the worst of it, the parts of it that remained with us for the rest of our lives after returning, at least for every one of us, who I know of who was a woman who served in Viet Nam. Mine was a guy named Gene. It was a few days before my hump day, the exact middle of my tour when I would be over the hump. I was lost in a heavy sleep under my bed when the phone started ringing. Still half asleep, I listened to the worlds. More casualties, Van. We need you in surgery. There's a bad one in the neuro room, she said. I need you to pump blood in there. Leading to the operating table was the largest trail of blood I had ever seen. I tried to walk quickly through it but slipped. When I regained my balance, my eyes were drawn to the gurney, where several people were transferring the wounded soldier from the green litter to the table. The lower portion of his jaw, teeth exposed, dangled from

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what was left of his face. It dragged across the canvas litter and then swung in the air as he moved from the gurney to the table. His tongue hung hideously to the side with the rest of the bloody meat and exposed bone. When he was on the table, Mac Schafner, the facial surgeon, dropped the lower jaw back into place. I held my breath to keep from getting sick. For a moment, I was glued to the spot. I thought I had gotten used to it all, but they kept getting worse. I wasn't sure I could handle this one. But the shout of the anesthesiologist, Jim Castellano, snapped me out of my trance.

'The son of a bitch is drowning in blood!' he screamed. 'Someone help me get a f---ing airway into him.' A gurgling came from the soldier's throat. Jim's hands were quick. 'Don't you dare die, you motherf---er.'

4NG Fanatics

There was an ugly, metallic coughing sound as the soldier bucked for breath.

'Breathe, damn you!'

A barely audible sound escaped. 'That's it, soldier. Come on.'

In the middle of the confusion, the neurosurgeon came into the room. He looked at the soldier on the table and shook his head. His face was red. 'Who the f--k woke me up for this GORK?'

'The brain doesn't look too damaged,' Mac said. 'You're wasting your time.'

'We can fix him,' Mac insisted, 'just give me a chance.' 'Bulls--t,' the neuro guy said, 'that sucker's going to die and there's not a f---ing thing you can do.'

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He stormed out of the room. It was all just another simple job where I could turn off my mind and try to forget that we were working on a person, but this one was different. The young soldier was not about to let me forget. During one of my circuits around the table, I accidentally kicked his clothes to the side. A snapshot fell from the torn pocket of his fatigue shirt. The picture was of a young couple, him and his girlfriend, I guessed, standing on the lawn in front of a two story house, perhaps belonging to her parents. On the back of the picture was writing, the ink partially blurred from sweat: 'Gene and Katie, May 1968.' I had to fight the tears as I looked from the picture to the helpless boy on the table. Now a mass of blood vessels and skin, so lacerated that nothing could hold them together. I had always held the notion that given enough time, anything could be stopped from bleeding I pumped 120 units of blood into

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that young man, yet as fast I pumped it in, he pumped it out. After hours of work, Mac realized it was futile. The boy had received so much banked blood that it would no longer clot. Now he was oozing from everywhere. Slowly, Mac wrapped the boy's head in layers of pressure dressings and sent him to post-op ICU to die. Gene and Katie, May 1968. While I cleaned up the room, I kept telling myself a miracle could happen. He could stop bleeding. Nothing was impossible. Please, God, help him. This wasn't merely another casualty, another piece of meat to throw on the table and try to sew back together again. He had been real, Gene. When I finished making the room ready for the next head injury, the next young boy, I walked to post-op to see Gene. I held his hand and asked him if he was in pain. In answer, he squeezed my hand weakly. I asked him if he wanted some pain medication, and he squeezed my hand again. All the ICU patients had

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morphine ordered for pain, and I asked one of the nurses to give Gene his morphine intravenously, knowing that while it would relieve his pain, it would also make him die faster. I didn't care at that point. I just wanted him to slip away painlessly, quickly, easily. I ran my finger over the edge of the picture before putting it into an envelope with his other possessions, then I walked outside, sat on the grassy hill next to post-op and put my head in my hands. I wouldn't cry, I told myself. I had to be tough. But I knew a profound change had already come over me. With the death of Gene and with the deaths of so many others, I had lost an important part of myself. The Lynda I had known before the war was gone forever.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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